

Designing for End-of-Life Planning with Older Adults: Digital Legacy, Artifacts, and Intergenerational Futures

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Abstract

HCI scholars have increasingly acknowledged death and the role that technology can play in death-related practices, such as planning for end-of-life in advance. Preferences for end-of-life planning vary across life stages. Older adults, in particular, are often at a life stage where they are more likely to have experienced loss and to be actively engaged in end-of-life planning, such as preparing advance directives or planning their estates. Despite this, older adults' perspectives on end-of-life planning remain understudied in HCI scholarship. To address this gap, my dissertation examines older adults' preferences for end-of-life planning through three interrelated aspects: preferences for digital data after death, crafting post-mortem remembrance, and co-designing end-of-life planning technologies. This dissertation yields in-depth empirical insights into older adults' end-of-life planning preferences and identifies design implications that enable intentional legacy-crafting by accounting for both explicit and invisible labor involved.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; • **Social and professional topics** → **Seniors**.

Keywords

older adults, remembrance, digital legacy, end-of-life planning, death, co-design

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1 Introduction and Background

While death is a 100% certainty for all of us, the fate of our artifacts¹ remains far less certain for most people. This pragmatization of mortality has, in turn, highlighted the relevance of technology in end-of-life planning, for example, as tools that support such

planning practices (e.g., password managers that can function as “digital wills” [17]). As such, understanding how to plan for death - particularly with respect to digital assets - has been an area of interest in HCI.

Research on end-of-life planning has extensively examined how to design for digital legacy. Scholars have explored how planners decide which digital assets are meaningful to preserve [7, 9, 16, 24], while also documenting challenges such as the overwhelming abundance of digital data [10] and the variety of devices that store it [25]. Examples of digital assets in this body work include social media [6, 9, 13], photos [27], and digital finance accounts [17, 21]. Across many of these studies, digital artifacts and accounts are treated as assets that carry meaning and value, akin to physical heirlooms [9]. Other work conceptualizes digital accounts—often social media accounts [9]—not as passive assets but as entities that actively mediate post-mortem identity and remembrance [4, 9, 15]. Such identities are often incomplete portrayals of the deceased, as many meaningful aspects of one's life remain unshared online due to factors such as privacy concerns [7, 15]. This line of work has also examined bereaved users' perspectives on memorialization practices on social media [4, 5], showing that different audience groups (e.g., loved ones, former acquaintances) may require distinct spaces for grieving [14]. Yet, current social media platforms rarely reflect these needs and often function as unintended sites of remembrance [14], where the deceased's original posts were seldom created with the intent of shaping their post-mortem narrative while alive. Across both schools of thought on designing for digital legacy, little attention has been paid to *when* individuals plan for death, particularly how this timing varies across stages of life.

Chen et al. note that stage of life is a critical factor for end-of-life planning [7]. For instance, the way a thirty-year old might think about their digital legacy can be very different from how a seventy-year old might think about their digital legacy. Yet, it is surprising that much of the existing scholarship on digital legacy and end-of-life planning adopts an age-agnostic approach. In this dissertation, I focus specifically on older adults, a population by virtue of their age are likely to have encountered loss [7], and be actively involved in purposeful end-of-life planning, such as preparing advance directives [19]. Given that today's older adults are among the first generations to have had sustained access to social media and other data-driven technologies [11], it is important to understand their preferences for digital legacy.

Beyond digital data alone, end-of-life planning must also account for artifacts more holistically, including both physical and digital belongings. This broader consideration is particularly important

¹In this work, I define artifacts as any belongings, physical or digital, that can be tied to an individual



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for older adults, who often purposefully curate artifacts for varied motivations [2], ranging from using items such as jewelry as “mnemonic anchors” to pass on life stories [1, 20, 26, 31] to ensuring that cherished intergenerational artifacts, such as artwork or letters, find appropriate homes with future generations [2, 20, 23]. However, much of what we know from prior work about older adults’ curation practices rarely situates these practices explicitly within the context of planning for death. Given that older adults are often already engaged in some form of end-of-life planning, understanding how they might intentionally curate artifacts with end-of-life in view is critical for supporting and designing for end-of-life preparations in a more holistic manner.

With this background, my doctoral research aims to understand older adults’ perspectives on technology-mediated end-of-life planning. Specifically, through this dissertation, I seek to address the following open questions:

- **RQ1:** What are older adults’ preferences for end-of-life digital data, and what shapes them?
- **RQ2:** How do older adults want to be remembered after death? How do they intentionally curate for it, and who do they envision as the audiences for their remembrance?
- **RQ3:** How can emerging generative technologies support older adults’ end-of-life planning and legacy creation?

In the sections that follow, I first describe my progress to date, followed by plans for my final study. I then conclude with the expected contributions of my dissertation. As part of my doctoral research, I have completed two studies. The first study (2.1) is published at the ACM Designing Interactive Systems (DIS) 2025 conference [34], the second study (2.2) is accepted to be published at the ACM CHI 2026 conference. The planning for the third study (2.3) is ongoing.

2 Work To Date

In my first study, I examine older adults’ preferences for end-of-life data planning and the factors that shape these preferences. I found that one of the key factors influencing preferences for end-of-life data planning was a desire to be *remembered for the good*. In my second study, I examine this thread of post-mortem remembrance in greater depth. I observed that participants intentionally considered not only family members but also wider social circles, such as workplace connections, as part of their end-of-life plans (e.g., as audiences for remembrance). For my final study, I seek to further examine this relational angle by engaging older adults and members of their broader social circles in designing and ideating end-of-life planning tools. I elaborate on all three studies in the following subsections.

2.1 Study 1: Unpacking Older Adults’ Preferences for End-of-Life Data Planning

2.1.1 Objective. Planning for one’s digital data has been studied extensively in HCI, yet older adults’ specific perspectives remain limited in this body of work. In my first study, I sought to address this gap by examining whether and how older adults think about their digital data as part of their end-of-life planning.

2.1.2 Methods. I conducted IRB-approved semi-structured interviews with 16 older adults aged 65 and above. I asked participants to reflect on different types of data, including social media, messages, photos and videos, fitness data, and data that track everyday online activities, which I refer to as *trace data* in this work. For each data type, I asked participants their understanding of what happens to their data by default after death, as well as their preferences for how the data should be managed, including what should happen to the data, who would be responsible for enacting these preferences, and when these preferences should be enacted. Additional methodological details are detailed in [34].

2.1.3 Notable Findings. Most participants were either unaware of what happens to their data by default after death or assumed it would simply be preserved. Only one participant had explicitly planned for their end-of-life data, despite many being engaged in other forms of end-of-life planning, such as drafting wills for physical assets. At the same time, the interviews prompted deeper reflection, with some participants taking active steps during the interviews, such as noting their preferences. In terms of preferences for managing end-of-life data, individuals expressed diverse views, including whether to preserve, delete, or donate their data, and when these actions should occur. Most identified their next of kin as the preferred heirs to manage their data post-mortem while those without a next of kin were often indifferent to what would happen to their data after death.

We identified four key factors that shaped participants’ preferences for managing their end-of-life data. First, participants’ *prior experiences with death*, such as near-death experiences or the loss of a loved one, shaped some of their preferences. For example, the sole participant who had experienced a near-death event (stage IV cancer diagnosis), was the only person who had planned for end-of-life data by preserving photos on Google Photos and Microsoft OneDrive and sharing account passwords with his nephew. Second, having witnessed profound technological changes throughout their lifetimes, participants noted that *what works today may not remain relevant tomorrow*. They highlighted concerns, including the obsolescence of storage devices over time (e.g., floppy disks, VHS tapes), the changing value of data (e.g., social media posts becoming less relevant over time), and the evolution of social norms encoded in digital data (e.g., changes in the social acceptability of language used in social media comments). These considerations led participants to question whether to preserve their data on cloud storage platforms, to choose deletion, or the need of adding contextual information when preserving data, such as explaining what a social media post meant at the time of creating it to avoid future generations misinterpreting it. Third, a desire to be *remembered for the good* shaped participants’ preferences. Some chose to preserve data, such as photos, to support remembrance by loved ones, while others expressed interest in donating data, such as health and fitness data, for the benefit of others, including public-good health research. Finally, participants’ *perceived concerns and risks* associated with end-of-life data also shaped their preferences. These included the emotional burden placed on the living and their heirs, such as data acting as triggers for grief, as well as privacy-related threats, including identity theft through their data. These concerns

often led participants to prefer deleting their data or making it non-identifiable.

2.1.4 Key Implications. Building on the different considerations older adults expressed for managing their data, such as adding context to their data, one important aspect to consider when designing for end-of-life data planning is accounting for this *post-mortem data work*. In particular, I note two key aspects of post-mortem data work. First is the work of *contextualizing post-mortem data*. Data such as social media posts and comments, which encode the social norms and language of their time, can mediate relationships with future generations in unintended ways when encountered without context, underscoring the importance of contextualization. Second is the *work of preventing infrastructural decay*. Participants' concerns about storage platforms becoming obsolete resonate with prior CSCW work showing that data work depends on technical infrastructures, and that the introduction of new technologies can contribute to infrastructural decay [22], such as when data formats (e.g., .WMV) become obsolete. Overall, these findings surface broader questions within my doctoral work, including how much responsibility individuals should bear in anticipating future interpretations of their data, who should perform post-mortem data work, and the literacy and skills required for performing post-mortem data work.

As I completed the first study, I observed that individuals' desires regarding how they wish to be remembered after death emerged as a salient factor shaping their preferences for managing digital data. This observation prompted me to further examine older adults' preferences for *post-mortem remembrance*, expanding the focus beyond digital data to consider artifacts more holistically, including both digital and material artifacts, as described further below.

2.2 Study 2: Crafting Remembrance Beyond the Self

2.2.1 Objective. My second study examines post-mortem remembrance by empirically investigating how older adults envision being remembered, which artifacts they curate, and for whom.

Prior digital legacy research has examined post-mortem identity and remembrance as mediated by technologies such as social media [6, 9]. However, this work has largely focused on technological ecosystems that operate after death, such as Facebook's Legacy Contact, often involving artifacts that were not intentionally created with remembrance in mind [6]. What remains understudied is how individuals intentionally curate for their post-mortem remembrance while they are still alive – a gap that my second study seeks to address.

2.2.2 Methods. For my second study, I conducted IRB-approved semi-structured interviews with 14 older adults who were already sensitized to death and its associated planning. Given the deeply personal and sensitive nature of the topic of how one wishes to be remembered after death, I emailed participants the interview questions in advance to allow time for reflection. Example questions included how participants would like to be remembered “50 years from now,” (a representative timeline intended to help participants envision a concrete, long-term future), and whether and how they

believed their digital and material artifacts might play a role in their remembrance.

2.2.3 Notable Findings. Our interview guide was designed to elicit how individuals *themselves* wanted to be remembered, that is, the subject of remembrance, and implicitly assumed that family members would serve as the primary audience of remembrance, as informed by prior work [9]. As participants thought about their post-mortem selves and remembrance, both the subject and audience of remembrance expanded toward wider relational circles. With respect to the subject of remembrance, all participants initially focused on their own lives as the subject of who should be remembered (e.g., as a “good husband” or “good grandparent”). But as they continued to think about their remembrance after death, their *sense of self often transcended the individual*. Participants wanted to support remembrance not only of themselves, but also of future generations (e.g., moments involving their children or grandchildren) and the past generations (e.g., lives of their parents and ancestors such as “dad’s World War II memories”) – sometimes all at once. Just as participants’ sense of who should be remembered expanded across generations, so did their sense of who might remember them: moving beyond immediate family members to wider communities (e.g., workplace connections) shaped by participants’ lifelong practices, including teaching or caregiving. For example, one participant, a retired instructor of medicine, hoped that his former students would remember him as a “good teacher” through the books he had written.

When curating artifacts to support remembrance, we noted that *embodied presence* [8, 18] was central to how participants imagined being remembered after death. The embodied presence was captured through physical traces (how they looked and sounded), temporal traces (materialized passage of body and lived experiences), relational traces (the intergenerational self), and the often untold reasons behind their actions. Physical embodiment was captured through curated artifacts such as photos, voice recordings or home movies. Temporal embodiment was captured through artifacts that materialized passage of body over time. For example, one participant wanted to preserve “older copies of [his] driver’s license going back 20 years” that captured his “gradual aging” through changing traits such as height and weight. Individuals also curated artifacts to preserve remembrance of the intergenerational self – including parents, grandparents, and descendants – foregrounding relational ties across generations. For instance, one participant’s photographs of baking and playing with her grandchildren preserved moments of co-presence, capturing both the relationship itself and the shared experiences that defined it.

2.2.4 Key Implications. Prior work has highlighted how end-of-life planning is often labor-intensive, involving tasks such as managing data dispersed across devices [25], identifying which accounts require attention [7, 10], and anticipating the emotional burden placed on those who inherit these accounts [10]. This work also includes contextualizing digital data, as noted in my first study [34]. Findings from my second study further show that the scale and nature of this work can become substantial when multiple audiences and diverse artifacts are involved. In particular, curating decades of accumulated physical and digital materials, selecting artifacts that encode different forms of embodied presence, and determining

where additional context is needed to prevent misinterpretation pose distinct challenges in intentional legacy-crafting. This labor is further compounded when different audiences, such as future generations and co-workers, require distinct forms of curation and explanation. Building on these findings, I suggest that emerging generative technologies may support aspects of this work. For example, AI-assisted tools could help identify and organize artifacts tied to specific life events for distinct audiences, such as lesson notes for former students or meaningful life moments captured on photographs for family members. At the same time, I caution against introducing new forms of invisible or emotional labor through such systems (e.g., monitorial labor to monitor or correct AI behavior [12]). Future systems must carefully negotiate how control, responsibility, and meaning are shared between older adults and computational systems, particularly when identifying artifacts, flagging risks of misinterpretation, and maintaining relational boundaries across audiences. Future work can further explore how AI-enabled legacy-crafting systems might recognize boundaries between audience groups by drawing on relational frameworks such as the social convoy model², allowing such systems to honor the relational boundaries individuals already maintain while alive.

2.3 Proposed Study: Co-Design Workshops with Older Adults and Co-Design Partners

Prior work has noted that collaboration is key in end-of-life planning, for example through multigenerational cloud platforms that support data sharing among intergenerational family members [7, 10]. However, participants in my studies considered audiences beyond immediate family members, and I noted the additional work involved in curating for multiple audiences. These insights raise open questions about how collaboration in end-of-life planning should be designed when responsibility for post-mortem data work and intentional legacy-crafting are actively negotiated by older adults. Together, they underscore the need for design approaches grounded in lived experiences with death and prior engagement in end-of-life planning. Moreover from prior research [28, 29, 32] and my own collaborative work [30], I have learned that older adults may share unique and creative perspectives when they are actively engaging in design activities rather than passively providing feedback on a topic. Building on this insight, for my third study, I plan to invite older adults conceptualize and design end-of-life planning tools. In addition to older adults, I will also involve their larger social circles (e.g., family, friends, co-workers) as *co-design partners* in the design process given how participants considered members beyond immediate family as their remembrance audience.

For this study, I plan to conduct a series of co-design workshops involving older adults and a co-design partner of their choice. Each pair will participate in three workshop sessions. The first will be an *ideation session*, during which participants will generate ideas for end-of-life technologies using design materials such as design cards. The second will be a *feedback session*, in which participants will reflect on existing technologies, such as Apple's Legacy Contact feature [33], informed by a technical overview presented by the research team. The third will be a *formative evaluation session*,

in which participants will interact with a prototype application designed to provoke reflection and discussion around end-of-life planning technologies. As older adults and their co-design partners engage in these design activities, I will attend to any tensions and considerations that arise during collaboration, such as differences in preferences for remembrance, data management practices, the distribution of emotional labor across stakeholders, and post-mortem data work (e.g., contextualizing and curating data). I will also examine intergenerational and relational factors that shape these interactions and influence end-of-life planning decisions. Attending to such considerations is particularly important given the sensitive nature of end-of-life planning, not only for older adults but also for the co-design partner who may eventually become bereaved.

3 Expected Contributions

The expected contributions of my doctoral research are as follows:

- Provides in-depth empirical insight into older adults' end-of-life planning perspectives—a population that has often engaged with death and its associated planning, yet remains understudied in end-of-life planning research. By centering older adults' lived experiences, this work informs the design of end-of-life planning tools for individuals currently engaged in planning as well as future generations of older adults.
- Advances design implications for end-of-life planning technologies by identifying design ideas that enable individuals to reclaim agency over their post-mortem narratives through intentional legacy-crafting. In doing so, this work surfaces nuanced considerations around who end-of-life planning is about (the subject), for whom it is intended (the audience), and the associated labor involved in post-mortem work.
- Will contribute to participatory design scholarship by examining how older adults engage in co-design when designing for end-of-life planning. Rather than treating collaboration as a neutral design setting, this work will surface the tensions, negotiations, and relational considerations that emerge when designing for death and remembrance, offering new insights into intergenerational and relational co-design practices.

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²The social convoy model conceptualizes a person's social world as concentric circles of closeness and reciprocal support [3, 35]

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